CENTRAL ASIA, EURASIA AND CONNECTIVITY

CENTRAL QUESTION AND THE → THE TWO OVERLAND ROUTES → POLICY CLASSIFICATION: WHAT BROAD-BASED → ECONOMIC-INTEGRATION INSTRUMENT: PROPOSAL TO → SCO PARTICIPATION MATRIX AS → DEDICATED REGIONAL FORMAT AND

Read the thick cyan rail from Stage 00 to the final core synthesis. Each card uses a concept-appropriate structure: the grey E card is optional enrichment only and never repairs missing core content.

◆ PRIMARY CORE FLOW · ◈ SUBORDINATE EXTRA · ◆ APPROVAL / REVIEW

CORE BEFORE EXTRA • prior artefacts unchanged • exact same master drives poster and tiles

Approval: FALSE • Pending user review • active generation g1 • explicit approval of this exact generation is required • all prior artifacts unchanged

00

STAGE 00 — CENTRAL QUESTION AND THE ROOT ACCESS CONDITION

CENTRAL QUESTION AND THE ROOT ACCESS CONDITION · HOW DOES A STATE WITH NO LAND ACCESS BUILD · ROOT CONDITION · PAKISTAN AND AFGHANISTAN LIE BETWEEN INDIA AND THE FIVE · AXIS 1 · CONNECT CENTRAL ASIA POLICY, 2012, BROAD-BASED · AXIS 2 · SCO SEAT

INTEREST / DOCTRINE

- CENTRAL QUESTION → how does a state with no land access build Eurasian presence?
- ROOT CONDITION → Pakistan and Afghanistan lie between India and the five Republics
- AXIS 1 → POLICY: Connect Central Asia Policy, 2012, broad-based

DIPLOMATIC MECHANISM

- AXIS 2 → FORUMS: SCO seat
- India-Central Asia Summit and Dialogue
- AXIS 3 → CORRIDORS: INSTC

CONSTRAINT / TRADE-OFF

- Ashgabat Agreement
- RULE → the constraint is the spine of the answer, not an afterthought

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: RULE → the constraint is the spine of the answer, not an afterthought.

01

STAGE 01 — THE TWO OVERLAND ROUTES AND WHY BOTH FAIL

THE TWO OVERLAND ROUTES AND WHY BOTH FAIL · ROUTE A · VIA AFGHANISTAN AND PAKISTAN · FAILS ON · TRANSIT UNAVAILABILITY AND AFGHAN INSTABILITY · ROUTE B · VIA XINJIANG, THEN ACROSS THE KARAKORAM AND HIMALAYAN RANGES · EXTREME GEOGRAPHY PLUS REQUIRED CHINESE COOPERATION

ACTOR / INTEREST	DECISIVE DISTINCTION	STATUS TRAP / LIMIT
ROUTE A → via Afghanistan and Pakistan	ROUTE B → via Xinjiang, then across the Karakoram and Himalayan ranges	SOURCE → Sikri on any Eurasia-to-India pipeline avoiding Afghanistan or Pakistan
FAILS ON: transit unavailability and Afghan instability	FAILS ON: extreme geography plus required Chinese cooperation	VERDICT → a structural constraint, not an engineering problem awaiting a solution

ACTOR / INTEREST

- ROUTE A → via Afghanistan and Pakistan
- FAILS ON: transit unavailability and Afghan instability

DECISIVE DISTINCTION

- ROUTE B → via Xinjiang, then across the Karakoram and Himalayan ranges
- FAILS ON: extreme geography plus required Chinese cooperation

STATUS TRAP / LIMIT

- SOURCE → Sikri on any Eurasia-to-India pipeline avoiding Afghanistan or Pakistan
- VERDICT → a structural constraint, not an engineering problem awaiting a solution

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: VERDICT → a structural constraint, not an engineering problem awaiting a solution.

02

STAGE 02 — POLICY CLASSIFICATION: WHAT BROAD-BASED ACTUALLY MEANS

POLICY CLASSIFICATION · WHAT BROAD-BASED ACTUALLY MEANS · CONNECT CENTRAL ASIA POLICY, LAUNCHED 2012 · SUSTAINED HIGH-LEVEL ENGAGEMENT WITH THE FIVE REPUBLICS · COUNTER-TERRORISM AND SECURITY-COUNCIL-LEVEL CONSULTATION · MARKET INTEGRATION PROPOSAL WITH THE EURASIAN SPACE · PEOPLE-TO-PEOPLE AND CULTURAL CONNECTIONS · FIVE REPUBLICS

CONNECT CENTRAL ASIA POLICY, LAUNCHED 2012

POLITICAL → sustained high-level engagement with the five Republics → SECURITY → counter-terrorism and security-council-level consultation → ECONOMIC → market integration proposal with the Eurasian space

INTEREST / DOCTRINE

- CONNECT CENTRAL ASIA POLICY, LAUNCHED 2012
- POLITICAL → sustained high-level engagement with the five Republics
- SECURITY → counter-terrorism and security-council-level consultation

DIPLOMATIC MECHANISM

- ECONOMIC → market integration proposal with the Eurasian space
- CULTURAL → people-to-people and cultural connections
- FIVE REPUBLICS → Kazakhstan

CONSTRAINT / TRADE-OFF

- TRAP → reducing a broad-based policy to an energy policy misstates its scope

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: TRAP → reducing a broad-based policy to an energy policy misstates its scope.

03

STAGE 03 — ECONOMIC-INTEGRATION INSTRUMENT: PROPOSAL TO OPEN NEGOTIATION

ECONOMIC-INTEGRATION INSTRUMENT · PROPOSAL TO OPEN NEGOTIATION · COMPREHENSIVE ECONOMIC COOPERATION AGREEMENT WITH THE EURASIAN SPACE · 3 JUNE 2017, ST PETERSBURG · INDIA–EAEU FREE-TRADE NEGOTIATION FORMALLY BEGINS · 22–25 JUNE 2026, MOSCOW · SECOND ROUND HELD · UNDER NEGOTIATION; NEITHER SIGNED NOR IN FORCE

PROPOSED → Comprehensive Economic Cooperation Agreement with the Eurasian space → 3 JUNE 2017, ST PETERSBURG: India-EAEU free-trade negotiation formally begins → 22–25 JUNE 2026, MOSCOW: second round held → STATUS → under negotiation; neither signed nor in force → ALSO CITED → Eurasian Economic Community and the Custom Union as existing fora

DATED OFFICIAL INSTRUMENT

- PROPOSED → Comprehensive Economic Cooperation Agreement with the Eurasian space
- 3 JUNE 2017, ST PETERSBURG: India-EAEU free-trade negotiation formally begins

EVIDENTIARY LEVEL IT REACHES

- 22-25 JUNE 2026, MOSCOW: second round held
- STATUS → under negotiation; neither signed nor in force

STATUS / CLAIM LIMIT

- ALSO CITED → Eurasian Economic Community and the Custom Union as existing fora
- RULE → cite the dated rounds as engagement, never as an achieved agreement

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: RULE → cite the dated rounds as engagement, never as an achieved agreement.

04

STAGE 04 — SCO PARTICIPATION MATRIX AS OF 3 AUGUST 2026

SCO PARTICIPATION MATRIX AS OF 3 AUGUST 2026 · FULL MEMBERS (10) · OBSERVERS (2) · DIALOGUE PARTNERS · PAKISTAN 2017 · IRAN 2023 · BELARUS 2024 · 1 SEPTEMBER 2025

OBSERVERS (2)	Afghanistan	Mongolia
DIALOGUE PARTNERS	15	
ACCESSIONS → Pakistan 2017	Iran 2023	Belarus 2024

ACTOR / INTEREST

- FULL MEMBERS (10)
- OBSERVERS (2)
- DIALOGUE PARTNERS

DECISIVE DISTINCTION

- ACCESSIONS → Pakistan 2017
- Iran 2023
- Belarus 2024

STATUS TRAP / LIMIT

- 1 SEPTEMBER 2025 → decision envisaging a single SCO Partner status
- PENDING → the enabling amendments had not entered into force
- TRAP → Sikri's observer list is period-specific and must be dated when quoted

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: TRAP → Sikri's observer list is period-specific and must be dated when quoted.

05

STAGE 05 — DEDICATED REGIONAL FORMAT AND ITS HONEST GAP

DEDICATED REGIONAL FORMAT AND ITS HONEST GAP · 27 JANUARY 2022 · FIRST INDIA-CENTRAL ASIA SUMMIT, HELD VIRTUALLY · 6 JUNE 2025 · FOURTH INDIA-CENTRAL ASIA DIALOGUE, NEW DELHI, FOREIGN-MINISTER LEVEL · ENVISAGED PREPARING THE GROUND FOR A SECOND SUMMIT · 16 OCTOBER 2025 · THIRD MEETING OF SECURITY COUNCIL SECRETARIES AND NSAS, BISHKEK

27 JANUARY 2022 — first India-Central Asia Summit, held virtually → 6 JUNE 2025 — fourth India-Central Asia Dialogue, New Delhi, foreign-minister level → envisaged preparing the ground for a second summit → 16 OCTOBER 2025 — third meeting of Security Council Secretaries and NSAs, Bishkek → 31 AUGUST–1 SEPTEMBER 2025 — SCO summit at Tianjin adopts the Tianjin Declaration

INTEREST / DOCTRINE

- 27 JANUARY 2022 — first India-Central Asia Summit, held virtually
- 6 JUNE 2025 — fourth India-Central Asia Dialogue, New Delhi, foreign-minister level
- envisaged preparing the ground for a second summit

DIPLOMATIC MECHANISM

- 16 OCTOBER 2025 — third meeting of Security Council Secretaries and NSAs, Bishkek
- 31 AUGUST-1 SEPTEMBER 2025 — SCO summit at Tianjin adopts the Tianjin Declaration
- Kyrgyzstan chairs 2025-26 with the next summit scheduled for Bishkek

CONSTRAINT / TRADE-OFF

- GAP → no second leader-level summit recorded as held by 3 August 2026

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: GAP → no second leader-level summit recorded as held by 3 August 2026.

06

STAGE 06 — CHABAHAR INSTRUMENT PRICED COMPONENT BY COMPONENT

CHABAHAR INSTRUMENT PRICED COMPONENT BY COMPONENT · 13 MAY 2024 · TEN-YEAR LONG-TERM CONTRACT, INDIA PORTS GLOBAL LIMITED WITH · IRAN'S PORTS AND MARITIME ORGANISATION · USD 120 MILLION · ANNOUNCED EQUIPMENT INVESTMENT; LEVEL · USD 250 MILLION · ANNOUNCED CREDIT WINDOW FOR MUTUALLY IDENTIFIED INFRASTRUCTURE

ACTOR / INTEREST	DECISIVE DISTINCTION	STATUS TRAP / LIMIT
13 MAY 2024 → ten-year long-term contract, India Ports Global Limited with	USD 120 MILLION → announced equipment investment; LEVEL: announcement	LEVEL → announced credit window, not disbursed finance
Iran's Ports and Maritime Organisation	USD 250 MILLION → announced credit window for mutually identified infrastructure	RULE → announcement and delivery are different evidentiary levels

ACTOR / INTEREST

- 13 MAY 2024 → ten-year long-term contract, India Ports Global Limited with
- Iran's Ports and Maritime Organisation

DECISIVE DISTINCTION

- USD 120 MILLION → announced equipment investment; LEVEL: announcement
- USD 250 MILLION → announced credit window for mutually identified infrastructure

STATUS TRAP / LIMIT

- LEVEL → announced credit window, not disbursed finance
- RULE → announcement and delivery are different evidentiary levels

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: RULE → announcement and delivery are different evidentiary levels.

07

STAGE 07 — SANCTIONS EXPOSURE PATH AND ITS CONSEQUENCE

SANCTIONS EXPOSURE PATH AND ITS CONSEQUENCE · 16 SEPTEMBER 2025 · UNITED STATES STATE DEPARTMENT REVOKES THE 2018 WAIVER · 29 SEPTEMBER 2025 · REVOCATION TAKES EFFECT · NON-EXPOSURE RUNS ONLY TO 26 APRIL 2026 · BEYOND THAT DATE · STATUS REQUIRES FRESH VERIFICATION

16 SEPTEMBER 2025 — United States State Department revokes the 2018 waiver → 29 SEPTEMBER 2025: revocation takes effect → ASSURANCE: non-exposure runs only to 26 April 2026 → BEYOND THAT DATE: status requires fresh verification → LEGAL CHARACTER → another state's domestic sanctions posture; exposure for entities

INTEREST / DOCTRINE

- 16 SEPTEMBER 2025 — United States State Department revokes the 2018 waiver
- 29 SEPTEMBER 2025: revocation takes effect
- ASSURANCE: non-exposure runs only to 26 April 2026

DIPLOMATIC MECHANISM

- BEYOND THAT DATE: status requires fresh verification
- LEGAL CHARACTER → another state's domestic sanctions posture; exposure for entities
- NOT → an international legal obligation binding on India

CONSTRAINT / TRADE-OFF

- CONSEQUENCE → the Iran work-around becomes a financing question, not a map question

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: CONSEQUENCE → the Iran work-around becomes a financing question, not a map question.

08

STAGE 08 — CORRIDOR STATUS LADDER

CORRIDOR STATUS LADDER · ANNOUNCED FRAMEWORK · INTERNATIONAL NORTH-SOUTH TRANSPORT CORRIDOR INTENDED TO REACH CENTRAL ASIA · OPERATING SEGMENTS EXIST · NOT A COMPLETED, FULL-CAPACITY CORRIDOR · 25 APRIL 2011 · ASHGABAT AGREEMENT SIGNED; INDIA JOINED FROM 3 FEBRUARY 2018 · A FACILITATION FRAMEWORK, NOT AN INFRASTRUCTURE-FINANCE MECHANISM

ANNOUNCED FRAMEWORK — International North-South Transport Corridor intended to reach Central Asia and Eurasia bypassing

OPERATING SEGMENTS exist → NOT a completed, full-capacity corridor → 25 APRIL 2011 — Ashgabat Agreement signed

DATED OFFICIAL INSTRUMENT

- ANNOUNCED FRAMEWORK — International North-South Transport Corridor intended to reach Central Asia and Eurasia bypassing Pakistan
- OPERATING SEGMENTS exist
- NOT a completed, full-capacity corridor

EVIDENTIARY LEVEL IT REACHES

- 25 APRIL 2011 — Ashgabat Agreement signed
- India joined from 3 FEBRUARY 2018 multimodal transport and transit corridor to the Persian Gulf and Gulf of Oman
- LIMIT: a facilitation framework, not an infrastructure-finance mechanism

STATUS / CLAIM LIMIT

- RULE → capacity and completion claims need independent dated verification

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: RULE → capacity and completion claims need independent dated verification.

09

STAGE 09 — COMPETITIVE FIELD AND THE LIMITS OF INDIAN AGENCY

COMPETITIVE FIELD AND THE LIMITS OF INDIAN AGENCY · THE REGION ABUTS MAJOR ASIAN POWERS AND WILL ALWAYS · SUSTAINED DIPLOMACY THROUGH A SEAT, A DIALOGUE AND CORRIDOR · RUSSIAN AND CHINESE PROXIMITY IS GREATER THAN INDIA'S · ACCEPT CO-DETERMINED OUTCOMES RATHER THAN CLAIMING REGIONAL PRIMACY · MIXED SCO MEMBERSHIP INCLUDES PAKISTAN · THE FORUM SUSTAINS ENGAGEMENT; IT CANNOT RESOLVE TRANSIT ACCESS · MULTI-ACTOR COMPETITION, EXPRESSLY NOT INDIAN DETERMINISM

INTEREST / DOCTRINE

- PROBLEM → the region abuts major Asian powers and will always attract foreign presences
- RESPONSE: sustained diplomacy through a seat, a dialogue and corridor instruments
- PROBLEM → Russian and Chinese proximity is greater than India's

DIPLOMATIC MECHANISM

- RESPONSE: accept co-determined outcomes rather than claiming regional primacy
- PROBLEM → mixed SCO membership includes Pakistan
- RESPONSE: the forum sustains engagement; it cannot resolve transit access

CONSTRAINT / TRADE-OFF

- VERDICT → multi-actor competition, expressly not Indian determinism

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: VERDICT → multi-actor competition, expressly not Indian determinism.

10

STAGE 10 — FUNCTIONAL COOPERATION INSIDE STRATEGIC MISTRUST

FUNCTIONAL COOPERATION INSIDE STRATEGIC MISTRUST · INDIA AND CHINA SEEK ENERGY FROM THE SAME SOURCES · THAT COMPETITION ONLY BENEFITS THE ENERGY PRODUCERS · SIKRI'S RECOMMENDATION · DEVELOP AN UNDERSTANDING ON ENERGY WITH CHINA · COOPERATION ON ONE FUNCTION ALONGSIDE UNRESOLVED STRATEGIC MISTRUST · THE WIDER INDIA-CHINA STRATEGIC RELATIONSHIP BELONGS TO TOPIC 03 · AVOIDS THE CRUDE CHOICE BETWEEN PURE RIVALRY AND NAIVE

ACTOR / INTEREST	DECISIVE DISTINCTION	STATUS TRAP / LIMIT
COMPETITION → India and China seek energy from the same sources	DIRECT RECOMMENDATION → develop an understanding on energy with China	BOUNDARY → the wider India-China strategic relationship belongs to topic 03
EFFECT → that competition only benefits the energy producers	COEXISTENCE → cooperation on one function alongside unresolved strategic mistrust	USE → avoids the crude choice between pure rivalry and naive partnership

ACTOR / INTEREST

- COMPETITION → India and China seek energy from the same sources
- EFFECT → that competition only benefits the energy producers

DECISIVE DISTINCTION

- SIKRI'S RECOMMENDATION → develop an understanding on energy with China
- COEXISTENCE → cooperation on one function alongside unresolved strategic mistrust

STATUS TRAP / LIMIT

- BOUNDARY → the wider India-China strategic relationship belongs to topic 03
- USE → avoids the crude choice between pure rivalry and naive partnership

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: USE → avoids the crude choice between pure rivalry and naive partnership.

11

STAGE 11 — ANSWER SPINE FOR A CENTRAL ASIA DEMAND

ANSWER SPINE FOR A CENTRAL ASIA DEMAND · STATE THE ABSENCE OF DIRECT LAND ACCESS BEFORE LISTING · POLICY, FORUMS AND CORRIDORS, EACH WITH ONE DATED INSTRUMENT · PRICE SANCTIONS EXPOSURE, THE UNHELD SUMMIT AND THE OPEN · CONVERT GOODWILL INTO RELIABLE ACCESS AS THE GRADED VERDICT

OPEN → state the absence of direct land access before listing any opportunity → BUILD → policy, forums and corridors, each with one dated instrument at its level → TEST → price sanctions exposure, the unheld summit and the open negotiation honestly → CLOSE → convert goodwill into reliable access as the graded verdict, predicting nothing

INTEREST / DOCTRINE

- OPEN → state the absence of direct land access before listing any opportunity
- BUILD → policy, forums and corridors, each with one dated instrument at its level

DIPLOMATIC MECHANISM

- TEST → price sanctions exposure, the unheld summit and the open negotiation honestly
- CLOSE → convert goodwill into reliable access as the graded verdict, predicting nothing

CONSTRAINT / TRADE-OFF

- OPEN → state the absence of direct land access before listing any opportunity
- BUILD → policy, forums and corridors, each with one dated instrument at its level

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: CLOSE → convert goodwill into reliable access as the graded verdict, predicting nothing.

E

EXTRA — SUBORDINATE ENRICHMENT — ONLY AFTER THE COMPLETE CORE

OPTIONAL ADVANCED ENRICHMENT · THE BROAD MULTILATERAL BODY THROUGH WHICH INDIA ENGAGES CENTRAL · INDIA-CENTRAL ASIA SUMMIT AND DIALOGUE · THE MORE DIRECT · INSTC AND CHABAHAR PORT · CONNECTIVITY FRAMEWORKS UNDER CONTINUING · INDIA-UZBEKISTAN BILATERAL BRIEF (AS ON APRIL 2026) · THE MOST RECENT

OPTIONAL DOCTRINE AND INSTRUMENT DEPTH

- SCO: the broad multilateral body through which India engages Central
- India-Central Asia Summit and Dialogue: the more direct,
- INSTC and Chabahar port: connectivity frameworks under continuing
- India-Uzbekistan bilateral brief (as on April 2026): the most recent

STATUS, DATE AND FIGURE LIMIT

- India-Eurasian Economic Union free-trade negotiation: the current form
- Direct PYQ boundary case (2024 Q10): the question asks for a "critical"
- CAUTION: Boundary case — Afghanistan's ambiguous status: Afghanistan sits at the
- CAUTION: Boundary case — India-China energy cooperation despite rivalry: Sikri's

COMPARATIVE DIPLOMATIC NUANCE

- CAUTION: Boundary case — SCO membership without privileged access: India's SCO
- CAUTION: No unilateral connectivity solution exists: both direct land routes
- CAUTION: SCO engagement is diluted by mixed membership: India's participation
- CAUTION: Energy-source competition with China risks negative-sum outcomes

OPTIONAL STATUS — This optional depth is unnecessary for a competent core answer; use it only for added nuance after the complete core has been written.

END OF MASTER CANVAS • poster embeds this exact master • tiled pages are overlapping crops of the same pixels